100 DAYS QUALITY MANAGEMENT CHALLENGE

BEL

BHARAT ELECTRONICS LIMITED

INTEGRATED ELECTRONICS QUALITY ENGINEERING

Electronic Systems Testing • Reliability • Failure Analysis
Risk-Based Quality Assurance • Validation

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Author: Jagriti Singh
Role: Quality Engineer

INDEPENDENT EDUCATIONAL CASE STUDY

A learning document using a hypothetical electronic-system testing scenario. Not an official BEL publication.

TECHNICAL LEARNING • EVIDENCE-BASED ANALYSIS • ENGINEERING JUDGEMENT

HOW TO USE THIS REPORT

This report separates general engineering principles from hypothetical scenario details.

• **Organisational context:** consult BEL's official public website for general company information.

• **Technical concepts:** general engineering learning material, not BEL internal procedures.

• **Hypothetical details:** the scenario and numerical example are invented; they do not describe an actual BEL incident.

• **Decision discipline:** a suspected cause is not a verified cause; action completion is not proof of effectiveness.

Section	Purpose
1. Electronics quality context	Quality, reliability, test integrity and validation.
2. Hypothetical problem	Define performance variation without assuming cause.
3. Critical characteristics	Requirements, risks and evidence.
4. Tools and technical analysis	Methods, examples and limitations.
5. Failure investigation	Evaluate plausible causes.
6. Risk assessment	Prioritise risks and mitigation.
7. Proposed solution	Match action to evidence.
8. Validation	Review results and effectiveness.
9. Interview preparation	20 original questions with answers.
10. References and disclaimer	Further reading and scope.

Core principle: electronic-system quality decisions require defined requirements, controlled testing, suitable measurements and documented evidence.

1. ELECTRONICS QUALITY ENGINEERING CONTEXT

Bharat Electronics Limited (BEL) is an Indian public-sector enterprise associated with defence electronics and related technology areas. Consult BEL's official website for company-specific facts. This report does not describe BEL's internal procedures or any actual project.

Electronic-system quality engineering considers whether components, assemblies and integrated systems meet requirements under specified conditions. Depending on the product, this may involve functional and environmental testing, reliability assessment, configuration control and failure analysis.

Key concepts

Concept	Meaning	Practical significance
Quality Assurance (QA)	Planned activities intended to provide confidence that requirements will be met.	Plans, responsibilities, reviews and records.
Quality Control (QC)	Activities used to assess whether an output meets requirements.	Inspection and test results evaluated against criteria.
Functional testing	Checks selected functions under defined conditions.	Confirms only the behaviours actually tested.
Reliability	Probability of required function over a stated time and conditions.	Needs defined failure criteria and suitable evidence.
Verification	Evidence that specified requirements are fulfilled.	Requirement-by-requirement checking.
Validation	Evidence that a system is suitable for intended use.	Connects results to intended needs.
Configuration control	Identification and control of versions and changes.	Keeps test results linked to the correct item/setup.
Traceability	Links an item and result to relevant records.	Supports investigation and independent review.

Why final inspection alone is not enough

An electronic system may pass a short functional test yet remain sensitive to environmental conditions, intermittent faults, configuration differences or measurement limitations. Evidence must match the requirements and risk. A test pass is meaningful only when the method, conditions, acceptance criteria and configuration are known.

2. HYPOTHETICAL ENGINEERING PROBLEM

Scenario status: Invented for education. Not an actual BEL incident, product failure, project or internal procedure.

Scenario: A hypothetical electronic control assembly produces inconsistent output readings during repeated functional tests. Some runs fall within an illustrative acceptance band; others approach or exceed its boundary. The team must determine whether variation is associated with the assembly, input conditions, test fixture, measurement system, connections, configuration or test execution.

Problem statement

Determine whether the variation is valid and meaningful, identify causes using controlled evidence, and select proportionate action. Do not assume the assembly is defective before verifying the test and measurement process.

Step	Question	Evidence
Requirement review	What output, conditions and acceptance rule apply?	Approved specification and test method.
Data integrity	Are values, units and calculations correct?	Raw data, logs and calculation records.
Configuration	Was the intended assembly/setup used?	Assembly identification, version and setup records.
Input conditions	Were inputs within defined conditions?	Recorded inputs and test conditions.
Fixture/connections	Could fixture or connection variation affect results?	Fixture checks and repeat runs.
Measurement system	Can the method support the decision?	Instrument ID, calibration, resolution and uncertainty.
Investigation	Which hypothesis best fits evidence?	Controlled comparison and reviewed findings.

All limits and values here are illustrative. Real conformity decisions must use the applicable authorised specification and decision rule.

3. CRITICAL QUALITY CHARACTERISTICS

Critical characteristics are properties important to functional performance, safety, reliability or requirements. Limits must come from applicable requirements—not be invented after results are observed.

Characteristic	Why it matters	Possible evaluation	Evidence
Output performance	Shows whether the defined function is achieved.	Compare output with requirement under stated conditions.	Specification, method and raw results.
Input stability	Input variation may affect output.	Record inputs and compare runs.	Input logs and conditions.
Connection integrity	Intermittent contacts can create unstable behaviour.	Inspect and test using approved method.	Inspection and connection records.
Environmental response	Conditions may affect electronics.	Test under specified conditions.	Condition records and results.
Measurement suitability	Poor measurement can cause false decisions.	Review range, resolution, calibration and uncertainty.	Instrument/method assessment.
Configuration	Versions may behave differently.	Confirm assembly and software/firmware identifiers as applicable.	Configuration/change records.
Reliability	Addresses performance over time.	Use defined reliability plan and model.	Failure records, exposure and assumptions.
Traceability	Supports reproducibility and investigation.	Link item, test, instrument and result.	Identifiers and records.

Define the acceptance rule before testing

Specify parameter, units, conditions, equipment, method, criteria and deviation handling before testing. Resolve ambiguity through the authorised process rather than improvising a limit.

4. QUALITY TOOLS AND TECHNICAL ANALYSIS

Choose tools to answer a defined engineering question. Their outputs support judgement; they do not automatically prove cause or establish acceptance.

A. Functional test planning

Defines functions, inputs, expected outputs, conditions, criteria and records.

When to use: Use before testing to make execution reviewable.

Limitation: Only supports behaviours and conditions covered by the test.

B. Check sheets and stratification

Organises results by unit, run, input, fixture, instrument, configuration and time.

When to use: Use to identify patterns and compare like-with-like.

Limitation: A pattern suggests a hypothesis; it does not prove causation.

C. Measurement-system evaluation

Reviews range, resolution, calibration, repeatability and uncertainty.

When to use: Use when readings differ or are near a limit.

Limitation: Calibration alone does not prove suitability.

D. FMEA

Lists possible failure modes, effects, causes and controls to prioritise risks.

When to use: Use during design, test planning or risk review.

Limitation: Scores are aids, not substitutes for judgement.

E. Root-cause analysis

Uses evidence, Five Whys, fishbone diagrams or fault trees to test hypotheses.

When to use: Use after defining the problem and verifying data.

Limitation: A plausible cause is not confirmed without evidence.

F. Design of Experiments (DOE)

Plans factor combinations to evaluate effects and interactions.

When to use: Use when several factors may influence a response.

Limitation: Depends on design, factor range and data quality.

G. Statistical analysis

Summarises centre, spread and trends using suitable methods.

When to use: Use when data structure supports the analysis.

Limitation: Small samples and changing conditions limit inference.

H. Reliability analysis

Evaluates probability of required function over stated time and conditions.

When to use: Use to plan and interpret reliability evidence.

Limitation: Claims depend on failure definition, model and conditions.

I. Configuration/change review

Checks whether the tested setup corresponds to the intended version.

When to use: Use when results differ across versions or after changes.

Limitation: Records must match the item tested.

J. Corrective-action effectiveness

Checks implementation and whether action achieves its intended result.

When to use: Use after cause is supported by evidence.

Limitation: Completion alone is not proof of effectiveness.

Illustrative numerical example

Suppose a hypothetical output is measured over five runs: 4.9, 5.0, 5.1, 5.0 and 5.0 units. Mean = (4.9 + 5.0 + 5.1 + 5.0 + 5.0) / 5 = 5.00 units. This summary alone does not establish conformity or reliability; acceptance criteria, uncertainty, run conditions and data validity must also be reviewed. These values are invented for learning.

Mean: $\bar{x} = \Sigma x / n$. It summarises the centre but can hide spread or unusual values.

Sample standard deviation: $s = \sqrt{[\Sigma(x - \bar{x})^2/(n - 1)]}$. Interpretation depends on sampling and data assumptions.

Measurement uncertainty: describes dispersion reasonably associated with a measured value; its estimate and coverage basis must be justified.

Specification limits differ from statistical control limits. Cp/Cpk should not be applied automatically to a small set of functional-test readings.

Reliability note

Reliability is the probability of performing a required function without failure for a stated time under stated conditions. A few successful tests do not establish long-term reliability. MTBF, when suitable for a repairable-system model, is a statistical average under that model—not a guaranteed life for each unit.

5. FAILURE INVESTIGATION

Investigate competing explanations systematically. The following are hypotheses, not confirmed causes.

Hypothesis	Evidence	Method	Possible action
Input variation	Input values and run logs.	Compare by input; controlled repeat.	Control/record relevant inputs.
Fixture/connection	Fixture status, connections, setup notes.	Inspect and repeat with verified setup.	Repair or standardise if confirmed.
Measurement limitation	Instrument ID, calibration, resolution, uncertainty.	Method review and suitable comparison.	Improve method or document limitations.
Configuration mismatch	Assembly/software/setup records.	Compare identifiers.	Restore intended configuration; assess affected data.
Execution differences	Procedure records and deviations.	Record review and observation.	Clarify steps and deviation control.
Assembly fault	Repeatable evidence under verified conditions.	Controlled test and authorised analysis.	Escalate if evidence supports it.
Factor interaction	Results across planned combinations.	DOE or suitable analysis.	Confirm with follow-up evidence.

Investigation sequence

Define problem → Confirm requirements → Verify data → Check setup and measurement → Form hypotheses → Test hypotheses → Review evidence → Confirm cause

An observed symptom, suspected cause, confirmed cause and corrective action are different. If evidence is inconclusive, state the uncertainty and identify what further evidence is needed.

6. RISK ASSESSMENT AND MITIGATION

Risk-based thinking evaluates what could go wrong, consequences, existing controls and whether additional evidence or action is needed. This table is educational, not BEL's official risk matrix.

Risk	Potential consequence	Mitigation	Evidence
Measurement issue	Incorrect pass/fail decision.	Review method suitability and uncertainty.	Instrument/method review.
Intermittent connection	Unstable test result.	Check connections and repeat in controlled setup.	Inspection and repeat-test record.
Uncontrolled configuration	Results may not be comparable.	Identify and control versions/changes.	Configuration records.
Unverified cause	Action may not resolve problem.	Test hypotheses before acting.	Investigation and confirmatory results.
Insufficient reliability evidence	Overconfident lifetime claim.	Define objective, exposure and decision rule.	Test plan and analysis.
Incomplete records	Decision cannot be reconstructed.	Preserve data, conditions and deviations.	Record review.

Risk workflow

Identify → Analyse → Evaluate against criteria → Treat → Monitor and review

Risk scores are prioritisation aids, not substitutes for evaluating consequences, uncertainty and requirements.

7. PROPOSED ENGINEERING SOLUTION

The response should match the evidence. Do not redesign an assembly simply because results vary; first determine whether variation is genuine and where it originates.

Evidence indicates	Possible response	Verification
Input conditions varied	Control and record inputs.	Repeat with verified inputs.
Fixture/connection issue	Correct confirmed fixture or connection problem.	Inspect and repeat with verified setup.
Measurement method unsuitable	Evaluate instrument, range, method and uncertainty.	Show method supports the decision.
Configuration mismatch	Confirm intended hardware/software/setup version.	Verify identifiers and repeat relevant tests.
Procedure execution differed	Clarify steps and deviation handling.	Review repeat execution records.
Assembly behaviour supported	Investigate assembly using authorised methods.	Test against requirements and review risk.

Corrective-action record

Stage	Question
Problem	What was observed and against which requirement?
Evidence	Are raw data and conditions reliable?
Cause	What evidence supports the cause?
Action	Does the action address the cause?
Verification	Was the action implemented as intended?
Effectiveness	Do suitable follow-up results support the intended effect?

Product disposition, retest acceptance, design changes and risk acceptance must follow applicable authorised requirements and procedures.

8. VALIDATION AND EXPECTED IMPACT

Plan evidence before declaring success. The validation method and acceptance criteria must match the requirement and the risk of an incorrect conclusion.

Check	Review question	Evidence
Requirements	Are criteria current and clear?	Approved specification and method.
Setup	Was the intended fixture/configuration used?	Setup and configuration records.
Measurement	Can the method support the decision?	Instrument status and uncertainty review.
Execution	Were tests performed as planned?	Run logs and deviations.
Results	Do results meet the decision rule?	Raw data, calculations and review.
Repeatability	Is behaviour consistent enough for the intended claim?	Suitable repeats and conditions.
Action effectiveness	Did the action achieve its intended effect?	Follow-up evidence.
Residual risk	Are remaining risks understood?	Risk review and authorised record.

Potential benefits include more trustworthy test results, better isolation of contributing factors, improved traceability and more defensible decisions. These are expected benefits of the approach, not measured outcomes from an actual BEL project.

9. TECHNICAL INTERVIEW PREPARATION

20 independently developed questions for electronic-system quality learning. These are not claimed to be actual BEL interview questions.

CATEGORY A — ELECTRONIC SYSTEM TESTING

Q1. Why should a functional test specify input conditions as well as output limits?

Answer: Output may depend on inputs. Recording both makes runs comparable and prevents interpretation without operating conditions.

Q2. What is an intermittent fault, and why can it be difficult to detect?

Answer: It appears only under certain conditions or at certain times. Short tests may miss it, so careful logging and repeatable conditions may be needed.

Q3. Why should a test fixture be treated as part of the measurement setup?

Answer: The fixture and connections can influence signals or introduce variation. Their condition and suitability matter when interpreting results.

Q4. What is the purpose of a burn-in test, and what can it not prove by itself?

Answer: Burn-in exposes a unit to defined operation or stress to reveal some early failures. Passing it does not prove lifetime reliability or suitability under all conditions.

CATEGORY B — ASSEMBLY AND DEFECT ANALYSIS

Q5. Why can a solder-joint defect cause intermittent electrical behaviour?

Answer: A defective joint can create an unstable connection, possibly affected by movement or temperature. Confirmation requires suitable inspection or testing.

Q6. Difference between an open circuit and a short circuit?

Answer: An open circuit interrupts the intended conductive path; a short circuit creates an unintended low-resistance path between points.

Q7. Why preserve a failed assembly before destructive examination?

Answer: Preservation allows records and non-destructive checks before examination changes the item's condition. Follow the authorised investigation plan.

Q8. What is the purpose of a fault-isolation procedure?

Answer: It narrows possible fault locations through ordered checks, reducing random part replacement and preserving diagnostic evidence.

CATEGORY C — MEASUREMENT AND TEST VALIDITY

Q9. Why check test leads, probes and connectors during an unexpected-reading investigation?

Answer: They may introduce poor contact, loading or unintended resistance. Checking them helps distinguish setup problems from item behaviour.

Q10. Difference between a test method and a test result?

Answer: The method defines how the test is performed and evaluated; the result is the observation or conclusion produced by applying it.

Q11. Why record failed and repeated test runs?

Answer: They may reveal intermittent behaviour or sensitivity to conditions. Omitting runs without a justified rule can bias the conclusion.

Q12. How can a baseline measurement help in fault investigation?

Answer: It provides a documented comparison point, if the reference condition and method are suitable and comparable.

CATEGORY D — CONFIGURATION AND RELIABILITY

Q13. Why can a hardware or firmware revision change affect comparison of results?

Answer: The change may affect function or test behaviour. Assess change impact and whether the configurations remain comparable.

Q14. Why define a failure criterion before reliability testing?

Answer: Without it, failures may be counted inconsistently and comparisons become ambiguous.

Q15. Difference between a failure symptom and a failure mechanism?

Answer: A symptom is observed behaviour; a mechanism is the process producing it. The mechanism requires evidence, not only a symptom description.

Q16. Why consider test coverage when reporting functional-test results?

Answer: A test exercises only the functions and conditions in its scope. Untested behaviour cannot be assumed to have passed.

CATEGORY E — SCENARIO-BASED ENGINEERING JUDGEMENT

Q17. An assembly passes a short test but fails after warming up. What should be investigated?

Answer: Preserve evidence and compare temperature, elapsed time, inputs, setup and measurement records. Use controlled testing to assess time- or temperature-related hypotheses.

Q18. A reading changes when a test cable is moved. What should the engineer do?

Answer: Do not treat the result as reliable until the setup is assessed. Inspect cable/connectors, document the observation and repeat under a controlled approved setup.

Q19. A replacement component makes the system pass once. Is the root cause confirmed?

Answer: Not necessarily. The change may coincide with another condition. Confirm the cause through evidence and suitable repeat tests, documenting configuration.

Q20. The result is acceptable but unit identification and test record do not match. Can it be assigned to that unit?

Answer: Not until the traceability discrepancy is resolved under the applicable process. The result cannot support a unit-specific decision without reliable identity association.

Interview principle: explain what evidence would distinguish competing causes; do not jump from a symptom directly to a conclusion.

10. REFERENCES AND DISCLAIMER

Official organisational source

Bharat Electronics Limited official website: https://bel-india.in/. Use for general company information and public corporate material. It does not verify the hypothetical scenario.

Technical references for further study

• Montgomery, Douglas C. *Introduction to Statistical Quality Control*. Wiley. Verify the edition used.

• Montgomery, Douglas C. *Design and Analysis of Experiments*. Wiley. Verify the edition used.

• O'Connor, Patrick D. T., and Andre Kleyner. *Practical Reliability Engineering*. Wiley. Verify the edition used.

• JCGM 100:2008. *Evaluation of measurement data — Guide to the expression of uncertainty in measurement (GUM)*. Joint Committee for Guides in Metrology.

• ISO 9001, *Quality management systems — Requirements*. Consult the applicable verified edition and applicability.

• ISO 31000, *Risk management — Guidelines*. Consult the applicable verified edition and context.

• ISO/IEC 17025, *General requirements for the competence of testing and calibration laboratories*. Consult the applicable verified edition where relevant.

These are potentially relevant learning references, not a claim that every listed standard applies to every BEL product. Verify edition and project-specific applicability.

Disclaimer

This document is an independent educational case study prepared by Jagriti Singh as part of the 100 Days Quality Management Challenge. It is not an official BEL publication and is not endorsed by BEL. The scenario and illustrative numbers are hypothetical and do not describe an actual BEL incident, product failure, project or internal procedure. Technical concepts are discussed for educational purposes. Actual engineering decisions must follow applicable requirements, approved procedures, safety obligations and authorised technical documentation.

FINAL TAKEAWAY: Electronics Quality Engineering requires more than a pass/fail reading. Reliable conclusions depend on valid test conditions, suitable measurement methods, controlled configurations, systematic fault investigation and documented evidence.